Different colour combinations

Yellow + red

How it feels

Hot, striking, loud. Red is warm and strong, and with yellow it forms a hot pair (fast food, advertising flyers).

When it suits

When you want **energy and attention**.

Specific shades



yellow + red
striking



golden + crimson
serious and warm



lemon + scarlet
fresh



ochre + brick
earthy



sunflower + wine
deep

In practice

A yellow and a red cushion. Red lipstick and a yellow scarf.

Watch out

Large areas of both can feel **garish**.

Yellow + orange

How it feels

Sunny, joyful. Orange is its warm neighbour, together they are like a setting sun.

When it suits

When you want a **festive, sunny** mood and warmth.

Specific shades



yellow + orange
striking



ochre + terracotta
earthy and calm



butter + apricot
gentle



golden + pumpkin
autumnal



sunflower + mandarin
playful

In practice

Yellow and orange flowers. A kitchen in warm tones.

Watch out

Rich yellow and rich orange can recall **fast food** or **warning graphics**.

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Yellow + green

How it feels

Fresh, spring-like. Green is yellow's other neighbour, mixed they give a spring yellow-green, lime.

When it suits

When you want **freshness and brightening**, even in the middle of winter.

Specific shades



yellow + green
naturally



ochre + sage
gentle and earthy



sunflower + dark green
rich



lemon + mint
fresh



golden + moss
woodland

In practice

Lime and green in a kitchen. A yellow scarf and a green coat.

Watch out

Yellow-green can be **sour**.

Yellow + blue

How it feels

Fresh and confident. Blue gives **calm**, yellow light. It is a classic pair you know from flags and from some brands. Mixed they give green.

When it suits

When you want **freshness and certainty**.

Specific shades



yellow + cobalt
striking



ochre + denim
earthy and calm



butter + light blue
gentle



golden + petrol
deep



vanilla + grey-blue
quiet

In practice

A yellow accessory in a blue room. Blue jeans and a yellow jumper.

Watch out

When there is too much yellow, it feels **garish**.

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Yellow + indigo

How it feels

Dramatic, deep. Indigo is a deep, dark blue-violet, and with yellow it forms a strong contrast, like gold in the evening sky.

When it suits

When you want **light in the dark**.

Specific shades


golden + indigo
deep


ochre + ink
dramatic


sunflower + midnight
evening-like


butter + plum blue
muted


yellow + navy
rich

In practice

An indigo wall with a yellow lamp. Evening lighting.

Watch out

A strong contrast feels dramatic, so dose it.

Yellow + violet

How it feels

Magical and playful. Violet is yellow's opposite on the colour wheel, the strongest contrast. Each makes the other glow.

When it suits

When you want something **magical and playful**. Yellow lights violet up and violet deepens yellow.

Specific shades


sunflower + purple
boldly


butter + lavender
tenderly


golden + plum
deeply


yellow + amethyst
playfully


vanilla + lilac
gently

In practice

Yellow flowers and a violet vase. A violet scarf and a yellow bag.

Watch out

Mixed together they turn grey.

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Yellow + pink

How it feels

Tender and cheerful. Pink is red diluted with white, and with yellow it forms sorbet-like, summery shades.

When it suits

When you want a **playful and kind** pair.

Specific shades


butter + powder
tenderly


sunflower + pale pink
playfully


ochre + dusty pink
earthy and gentle


yellow + fuchsia
boldly


golden + salmon
warmly

In practice

Powder pink and butter yellow in a room. A pink jumper and a yellow scarf.

Watch out

Watch that it is not **too sweet**.

Yellow + grey

How it feels

Modern and calm. Grey mutes and firms up yellow, and yellow enlivens grey.

When it suits

When there is too much of everything. Grey-yellow is widely used today.

Specific shades


sunflower + anthracite
modern


butter + light grey
calm


vanilla + dove
gentle


golden + slate
elegant


lemon + silver-grey
quiet

In practice

A grey sofa and a yellow cushion. A grey dress and a yellow scarf.

Watch out

Grey should not **drown out** yellow, give it the floor.

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Yellow + brown

How it feels

Earthy, safe. Brown and yellow are a natural pair. Ochre, mustard, clay. Yellow warms, brown holds.

When it suits

When you want **support and warmth**, a feeling of home.

Specific shades


sunflower + chocolate
richly


butter + caramel
softly


ochre + dark wood
earthy


golden + chestnut
autumnal


vanilla + beige
gently

In practice

Wooden furniture and yellow textiles. Mustard and brown.

Watch out

Brown can take command, leave yellow **enough room**.

Yellow + white

How it feels

Fresh and bright. White gives yellow space. Yellow breathes and white gives room.

When it suits

When you want a **clean, airy** impression.

Specific shades


lemon + pure white
fresh


butter + cream
soft


vanilla + milky
quiet


ochre + ivory
natural


yellow + linen
calm

In practice

A white kitchen with a yellow accessory. A white shirt and a yellow scarf.

Watch out

Yellow stands out next to white, but on white it can be **hard to read**. Watch for weak contrast.

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Yellow + black

How it feels

Strong and warning. Black and yellow are the most visible pair of all. Bees, warnings, taxis, signage.

When it suits

When you want **strong contrast and attention**.

Specific shades

- yellow + black — *striking*
- golden + charcoal — *elegant*
- butter + graphite — *gentle*
- sunflower + anthracite — *rich*
- lemon + black — *dark*

In practice

Black accessories and a yellow accent. A black bag with a yellow scarf.

Watch out

When there is too much, it feels **noisy**.

Yellow + gold

How it feels

Sun and honey. Yellow makes gold glow and gold gives yellow depth. Together they feel joyful and warming.

When it suits

When you want **light and joy**.

Specific shades

- yellow + gold — *cheerful*
- ochre + antique gold — *golden*
- butter + champagne — *fresh*
- lemon + rich gold — *radiant*
- mustard + matt gold — *muted*

In practice

A yellow scarf and gold jewellery. A yellow wall and a gold frame.

Watch out

At the same intensity the colours pull against each other. Leave gold **as an accent**.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **mute and firm up** yellow, add **grey**, **white** or **blue**.
- When you want to **ground** it, add **brown**, **ochre** or **natural materials**.
- When you want to **freshen** it, add **green** or **turquoise**.
- When you want to **make it glow**, **violet**, **indigo** or **black** will help.

Colour theory and symbolism are inspiration, not a rule. The best measure is how you really feel next to the colour.

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